

D434

Future Focused Total Rewards

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

Method © 2026 Erik Daniel Lindquist — Course Mastery Coach, armored drill. Items drafted with AI assistance under his direction.

How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A tech company losing engineers raised base pay 5%, but exit interviews cite no growth path, no flexible work, and no recognition. The company recently moved into an energy-efficient building. What is the best total-rewards response?

- A. Promote the new building in recruiting ads.
- B. Give another 5% raise.
- C. Add career paths, flexible work options, and a recognition program alongside competitive pay.
- D. Accept that money is always the only real motivator.

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	☐ sure ☐ unsure ☐ guess
-----------------------------	---	-----------------------	---

2.

An analyst with an MBA earns \$66,000. Her pay range is \$48,000 to \$72,000 with a \$60,000 midpoint. What is her compa-ratio?

- A. 0.92
- B. 1.10
- C. 0.91
- D. 1.375

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	☐ sure ☐ unsure ☐ guess
-----------------------------	---	-----------------------	---

3. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A range midpoint is \$80,000. What salary gives a compa-ratio of 0.95?

- A. \$84,000
- B. \$84,211
- C. \$76,000
- D. \$4,000

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	☐ sure ☐ unsure ☐ guess
-----------------------------	---	-----------------------	---

4.

A fully remote job has a pay range of \$50,000 to \$75,000 with a midpoint of \$62,500. What is the range spread?

- A. 40%
- B. 33.3%
- C. \$25,000
- D. 50%

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
-----------------------------	---	-----------------------	----------------------------------

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A symmetric pay range has a \$90,000 midpoint and a 50% range spread. What is the range minimum?

- A. \$67,500
- B. \$108,000
- C. \$45,000
- D. \$72,000

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
-----------------------------	---	-----------------------	----------------------------------

6.

A hospital facing a severe shortage of ICU nurses sets their pay 10% above the market median. It also offers free parking. Which pay policy is this?

- A. Match
- B. Lead
- C. Lag
- D. A benefits-led policy, because of the free parking

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
-----------------------------	---	-----------------------	----------------------------------

7. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A startup sets base pay 5% below market but offers strong equity upside and fast promotions. Which base-pay policy is this?

- A. Match
- B. Lead
- C. Illegal, because pay must always equal market
- D. Lag

Target word _____	The one fact that decides _____	Answer ____	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
-----------------------------	---	-----------------------	----------------------------------

8.

A senior accountant role and a marketing manager role each score 540 points on the company's point-factor plan for skill, effort, responsibility, and working conditions. The marketing team sits on a newly renovated floor. What does this imply?

- A. The jobs have similar internal value and would usually share a pay grade.
- B. The marketing role should be paid more because of its new floor.
- C. Both employees must get identical salaries regardless of performance.
- D. The points rate how well each person performs.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

At a store located in a shopping mall, a male assistant manager earns \$4,000 more a year than a female assistant manager. They have the same duties, were hired the same year, and have the same performance ratings. Which statement is correct?

- A. It is lawful because stores in malls are exempt.
- B. This is a likely Equal Pay Act violation unless a factor other than sex explains the gap.
- C. It would be lawful if their job titles were different.
- D. Every pay gap between a man and a woman is always illegal.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10.

A merit matrix gives employees rated Exceeds: 6% if compa-ratio is below 0.90, 4% if 0.90–1.10, and 2% if above 1.10. An employee rated Exceeds, who recently relocated from Denver, earns \$57,000 with a \$60,000 midpoint. What is her raise?

- A. \$2,280
- B. \$2,400
- C. \$1,140
- D. \$3,420

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Two employees are both rated Meets. Employee A has a compa-ratio of 0.85; employee B has 1.15. Under a typical merit matrix, who gets the larger percentage increase?

- A.** Employee B
- B.** The same, since both are rated Meets
- C.** Employee A
- D.** Always the higher-paid employee, who is more valuable

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12.

A 40-employee startup founded by two former college athletes reviews its benefits. Under federal law, which is legally required?

- A.** Employer Social Security and Medicare contributions
- B.** Employer-sponsored health insurance
- C.** A 401(k) matching contribution
- D.** Paid vacation, since all employers must offer it

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer C Concept 1

A tech company losing engineers raised base pay 5%, but exit interviews cite no growth path, no flexible work, and no recognition. ~~The company recently moved into an energy efficient building.~~ What is the best total-rewards response?

Target word: best response **Decides:** Exit reasons are non-pay.

A	Camouflage	Answers the building detail, not retention.
B	Dropped element	Drops the non-pay reasons people named.
C	Correct	Targets the reasons people give for leaving.
D	Absolute language	Ignores the exit data.

2. Answer B Concept 2

An analyst ~~with an MBA~~ earns \$66,000. Her pay range is \$48,000 to \$72,000 with a \$60,000 midpoint. What is her compa-ratio?

Target word: compa-ratio **Decides:** $\text{Pay} / \text{midpoint} = \$66,000 / \$60,000$.

A	Confusion set	Divides by the range maximum.
B	Correct	$\$66,000 / \$60,000 = 1.10$.
C	Inverted operation	Midpoint / pay, divided the wrong way.
D	Wrong stem number	Divides by the range minimum.

3. Answer C Concept 2 • transfer

A range midpoint is \$80,000. What salary gives a compa-ratio of 0.95?

Target word: solve for salary **Decides:** $\text{Salary} = \text{midpoint} \times \text{compa-ratio}$.

A	Adjacent category	Adds 5% instead of taking 95%.
B	Inverted operation	$\$80,000 / 0.95$ divides instead of multiplying.
C	Correct	$\$80,000 \times 0.95 = \$76,000$.
D	Dropped element	The gap below midpoint, not the salary.

4. Answer D Concept 3

A ~~fully remote~~ job has a pay range of \$50,000 to \$75,000 with a midpoint of \$62,500. What is the range spread?

Target word: range spread **Decides:** $(\$75,000 - \$50,000) / \$50,000$.

A	Confusion set	Divides the width by the midpoint.
B	Inverted operation	Divides the width by the maximum.
C	Dropped element	The dollar width, not the spread.
D	Correct	$\$25,000 / \$50,000 = 50\%$.

5. Answer D Concept 3 • transfer

A symmetric pay range has a \$90,000 midpoint and a 50% range spread. What is the range minimum?

Target word: solve for minimum **Decides:** $\text{Min} = \text{midpoint} / (1 + 0.25)$.

A	Inverted operation	Subtracts 25% of the midpoint instead of dividing.
B	Confusion set	That is the range maximum.
C	Dropped element	Takes 50% of the midpoint, dropping the range logic.
D	Correct	$\$90,000 / 1.25 = \$72,000$; $\text{max} = \$108,000$; $(\$108,000 - \$72,000) / \$72,000 = 50\%$.

6. Answer B Concept 4

A hospital facing a severe shortage of ICU nurses sets their pay 10% above the market median. ~~It also offers free parking.~~ Which pay policy is this?

Target word: pay policy **Decides:** Pay set above market.

A	Confusion set	Match pays at market.
B	Correct	Paying above market to attract scarce talent.
C	Inverted operation	Lag pays below market.
D	Camouflage	Parking does not decide the pay policy.

7. Answer D Concept 4 • transfer

A startup sets base pay 5% below market but offers strong equity upside and fast promotions. Which base-pay policy is this?

Target word: reverse: from description to policy **Decides:** Base pay below market.

A	Confusion set	Match pays at market.
B	Inverted operation	Lead pays above market.
C	Absolute language	No law requires market-rate pay above minimum wage.
D	Correct	Below-market base pay offset by other rewards.

8. Answer A Concept 5

A senior accountant role and a marketing manager role each score 540 points on the company's point-factor plan for skill, effort, responsibility, and working conditions. ~~The marketing team sits on a newly renovated floor.~~ What does this imply?

Target word: implication of equal points **Decides:** Equal job value.

A	Correct	Job evaluation supports internal equity through grading.
B	Camouflage	Office space is not a compensable factor here.
C	Absolute language	Pay within a grade still varies by performance and experience.
D	Adjacent category	Job evaluation rates jobs, not people.

9. Answer B Concept 6

At a store ~~located in a shopping mall~~, a male assistant manager earns \$4,000 more a year than a female assistant manager. They have the same duties, were hired the same year, and have the same performance ratings. Which statement is correct?

Target word: EPA analysis **Decides:** Substantially equal work, no explaining factor.

A	Camouflage	Location type does not create an exemption.
B	Correct	Equal work at the same site with no lawful explanation.
C	Adjacent category	Actual job content, not title, decides.
D	Absolute language	Seniority, merit, production, and other non-sex factors can justify gaps.

10. Answer A Concept 7

A merit matrix gives employees rated Exceeds: 6% if compa-ratio is below 0.90, 4% if 0.90-1.10, and 2% if above 1.10. An employee rated Exceeds, ~~who recently relocated from Denver~~, earns \$57,000 with a \$60,000 midpoint. What is her raise?

Target word: raise amount **Decides:** Compa-ratio = 0.95, in the 4% cell.

A	Correct	$\$57,000 / \$60,000 = 0.95 \rightarrow 4\% \times \$57,000 = \$2,280.$
B	Confusion set	Applies 4% to the midpoint instead of her pay.
C	Inverted operation	Uses the 2% cell, as if she were high in range.
D	Adjacent category	Uses the 6% cell for compa-ratios below 0.90.

11. Answer C Concept 7 • transfer

Two employees are both rated Meets. Employee A has a compa-ratio of 0.85; employee B has 1.15. Under a typical merit matrix, who gets the larger percentage increase?

Target word: reverse: from position to raise **Decides:** Lower in range gets more.

A	Inverted operation	Higher in range gets less.
B	Dropped element	Drops the range-position axis.
C	Correct	Lower compa-ratio at the same rating earns a larger percentage.
D	Absolute language	Contradicts how merit matrices work.

12. Answer A Concept 8

A 40-employee startup ~~founded by two former college athletes~~ reviews its benefits. Under federal law, which is legally required?

Target word: required benefit **Decides:** Employer FICA contributions are mandatory.

A	Correct	Required federal payroll contributions.
B	Adjacent category	The ACA employer mandate applies at 50 or more full-time-equivalent employees.
C	Confusion set	Retirement plans are voluntary.
D	Absolute language	No federal law requires paid vacation.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	5	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	1	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	5	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	8	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	6	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	7	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	4	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Total rewards breadth	Total rewards include pay, benefits, well-being, flexibility, development, and recognition, designed together.	Treating every retention problem as a pay problem.	Exit data naming non-pay reasons.
2	Compa-ratio	Compa-ratio = employee pay / range midpoint.	Dividing by the range minimum or maximum, or inverting.	Pay plus a range with a midpoint.
3	Range spread and range math	Range spread = (max – min) / min; with a symmetric range, min = midpoint / (1 + spread / 2).	Dividing the width by the maximum or the midpoint.	Minimum, midpoint, and maximum figures.
4	Lead, lag, and match	Lead pays above market, match pays at market, lag pays below market, often offset by other rewards.	Confusing lag with lead when other perks are strong.	Pay set above or below the market median.
5	Job evaluation and internal equity	Job evaluation rates jobs, not people; jobs with similar value usually share a pay grade, with actual pay then varying by performance and market.	Thinking equal job points mean identical salaries.	Two jobs scored with the same point-factor plan.
6	Equal Pay Act	Men and women doing substantially equal work in the same establishment must get equal pay unless the gap is explained by seniority, merit, production, or another factor other than sex.	Relying on different job titles to justify a gap.	Same duties, same site, different pay by sex.
7	Merit matrix	Merit increases rise with performance and fall as compa-ratio rises, so high performers low in range move up fastest.	Giving the biggest raise to the highest-paid person in range.	Performance rating plus position in range.
8	Legally required vs. voluntary benefits	Federally required employer benefits include Social Security and Medicare contributions, unemployment insurance, and (by state law) workers' compensation; most others are voluntary.	Assuming health insurance, retirement matches, or paid vacation are required for every employer.	A small employer's benefit list.

Course scope (public description): Compensation today is about more than salary. It is about creating complete reward strategies that support both business goals and employee needs. This course examines the design of pay, benefits, and recognition programs that are competitive, legally compliant, and aligned with organizational culture. You will learn how HR professionals use total rewards to attract talent, motivate employees, and reinforce organizational values.